Analysis of the UN Security Council's discourse about the wars in Ukraine and Gaza

DIS 4013 – Data Science - 20/10/2025

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Executive Summary

This report presents a quantitative and comparative analysis of the discourse of the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) regarding the conflicts in **Ukraine** and **Gaza**, focusing on the period from 2017 to 2025. The main objective was to assess the consistency of prioritizing civilian protection depending on the geopolitical context.

Key Findings:

- **Clear Thematic Differences:** The word frequency and TF-IDF analysis reveal a notable thematic divergence between the two conflicts. Discourse on Ukraine focuses primarily on issues of sexual and physical violence, the treatment of prisoners of war (POWs) and detainees, and the impact on children and education in specific regions (Crimea, Kherson, Zaporizhzhia). In contrast, discourse on Gaza highlights territorial concerns and settlement activities, as well as the use of force and security.
- **Neutral Tone:** The sentiment analysis shows that documents in both corpora are written in generally neutral language, with average polarity values very close to zero (Ukraine max. 0.14; Gaza average 0.0349), which aligns with expectations for UN reports.
- **Overlap in Violations:** Combined thematic analysis and clustering confirm that some human rights violation themes are common to both wars, including sexual violence, detention/torture, and civilian deaths. However, topics such as land/colonial issues are specific to Gaza, while occupation-related concerns and restrictions on freedom/education are more prominent in the case of Ukraine.

In conclusion, while the tone of UN communications remains objectively neutral, the thematic focus and prioritization of issues vary significantly between the two conflicts, suggesting that **geopolitical dynamics influence the visibility of specific topics**.

Background & Objectives

The United Nations (UN) is the main body responsible for maintaining international peace and security. In recent years, the world has witnessed multiple simultaneous conflicts — in Ukraine, Gaza, Syria, Yemen, and Sudan — testing the Council's ability to act effectively and coherently.

The language and priorities expressed in the UN's official reports and communications have a direct impact on international perception, humanitarian mobilization, and coordination among international actors. Understanding how the Council addresses these conflicts in its discourse allows for an assessment of its consistency, neutrality, and impartiality, as well as the influence of geopolitical dynamics on its decisions.

With the aim of highlighting the usefulness of data science for research, we unfortunately had to select among numerous, equally dramatic conflicts. Given the media and political significance of the conflicts in Ukraine (since 2022) and Gaza (particularly 2023–2024), these two cases provide an ideal analytical ground to examine the evolution of the UN's discourse, identify dominant themes, and observe how the tone and prioritization of civilians vary according to the geopolitical context.

Policy question: To what extent does the United Nations prioritize civilian protection consistently in its reporting and humanitarian policy messaging for the wars in Ukraine and Gaza, and how do geopolitical contexts influence this prioritization?

The main objective of this project is the analysis and comparison of UN discourse on Ukraine and Gaza. More specifically, we aim to:

- Identify dominant themes in UN reports, such as civilian protection, humanitarian access, calls for ceasefires, and the responsibilities of actors.
- Measure the tone and framing of these communications to detect differences or similarities between the two conflicts.
- Observe the temporal evolution of priorities by the UN.

In summary, this study demonstrates how text analysis and data science tools can enrich the understanding of diplomatic practices, providing an objective and measurable view of the evolution of the Council's discourse.

Data & Process

To conduct this analysis, we relied on data from the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR).

Established in 1993 by General Assembly Resolution 48/141, the OHCHR's mandate is to promote and protect all human rights guaranteed under international law. The Office serves as the UN's principal authority for monitoring fundamental rights violations, advising states, and supporting mechanisms of the Human Rights Council (HRC). Its reports and communications are an official, neutral, and rigorous source for observing conflict situations.

For this project, we utilized the OHCHR's publicly available document databases. Two distinct document sets were collected:

- **Ukraine:** 85 documents covering the human rights situation in Ukraine within the context of the Russo-Ukrainian armed conflict, specifically in temporarily occupied territories including Crimea and Sevastopol.
- **Gaza:** 43 documents concerning the human rights situation in the occupied Palestinian territories, particularly in the context of hostilities in Gaza and the West Bank.

To ensure the consistency and quality of our analysis corpus, we selected documents during the automated scraping process described in the following section. Only documents produced by the General Assembly (coded "A/") and the Human Rights Council (coded "A/HRC/") were retained.
For Ukraine we also included documents by the United Nations Human Rights Office of the High Commissioner as well as documents by the Security Council (coded "S/").

For clarity, there is a standardized coding system for documents: the first letter identifies the main body (A for General Assembly, S for Security Council, E for Secretariat), the following letters indicate the subsidiary body or specific type, the first set of numbers represents the session or year, and the final number corresponds to the document number for that session. For example, a document coded "A/HRC/56/69" refers to document no. 69 of the 56th session of the Human Rights Council, submitted to the General Assembly.

This methodological choice is based on several criteria:

1. These documents represent the most complete and structured official reports of the system.
2. They undergo an institutional validation process ensuring their reliability.
3. Their standardized format facilitates the extraction and comparison of information.

After applying these selection criteria, our final corpus consists of:

- **Ukraine:** 15 documents (from an initial 85) spanning July 2022 to August 2025 (3 years and 1 month)
- **Gaza:** 25 documents (from an initial 43) spanning November 2017 to March 2025 (7 years and 4 months)

This temporal depth allows us to analyze not only the recent situation but also to identify long-term dynamics in how the United Nations addresses these two conflicts.

To prepare the documents for analysis, we followed several data processing steps:

1. **Data Cleaning:** First, we started with cleaning the data and removing unnecessary information. We analysed the different types of documents that we had and what needed to be removed for each of them, so that we are left with only relevant information. We also had to remove the headers and footers of every page as well as notes on the end of the page as that information was not very important for our analysis.
2. **Tokenization and lemmatization:** With the cleaned texts, we first did sentence tokenization, and after word tokenization. Then, we did POS tagging on the words and lemmatization.
3. **Stopwords removal:** For stop words, we first got the stop words from the nltk package and then updated them by adding our own custom words. We removed words that would be very common in every document such as “Russia”, “Ukraine”, etc. as well as words that are typical for such reports like ‘humanitarian’, ‘un’, ‘security’, ‘civilian’ as we wanted to see only unique words in the most common words for each document so that we can decide what each document was about specifically or what it emphasised on.
4. Then we created lists for most common words, most common nouns, most common verbs, and most common adjectives.
5. Lastly, this is all stored in a dataframe/dictionary for easy access that contains columns like: “Title”, “Date”, “Text”, “Tokenized sentences”, “Tokenized words”, “Lemmatized words”, “Filtered words”, “Processed text”, etc.

	Title	Date	Text	Tokenized sentences	Tokenized words	Lemmatized words	Filtered words	Processed text	Most Common words	Nouns	Most Common Nouns	Verbs	Most Common verbs	Adjectives	Most Common Adjective
0	A/77/220 - 25 July 2022	2022-07-25	The present report is submitted pursuant to Ge...	[The present report is submitted pursuant to G...	[[The, present, report, is, submitted, pursuan...	[(the, DT), (present, JJ), (report, NN), (be, ...	[(present, JJ), (report, NN), (submit, VBN), (...	present report submit pursuant general assembl...	[(crimea, 71), (court, 44), (include, 42), (la...	[report, pursuant, general, assembly, resoluti...	[(crimea, 71), (court, 44), (law, 41), (case, ...	[submit, request, report, make, include, impro...	[(include, 42), (occupy, 16), (convict, 13), (...	[present, secretarygeneral, seventy, seventh, ...	[(international, 22), (public, 20), (military,...
1	A/HRC/53/64 - 26 May 2023	2023-05-26	In the present interim report, the Secretary-G...	[In the present interim report, the Secretary-...	[[In, the, present, interim, report, ,, the, S...	[(in, IN), (the, DT), (present, JJ), (interim,...	[(present, JJ), (interim, JJ), (report, NN), (...	present interim report secretarygeneral descri...	[(crimea, 83), (case, 45), (authority, 34), (i...	[report, progress, implementation, general, as...	[(crimea, 83), (case, 45), (authority, 34), (a...	[describe, make, provide, improve, reach, publ...	[(include, 32), (continue, 15), (arm, 15), (do...	[present, interim, secretarygeneral, present, ...	[(military, 16), (international, 14), (public,...
2	S/2023/413 - 22 June 2023	2023-06-22	Introduction The present report, which covers ...	[Introduction The present report, which covers...	[[Introduction, The, present, report, ,, which...	[(introduction, NNP), (the, DT), (present, JJ)...	[(introduction, NNP), (present, JJ), (report, ...	introduction present report cover period janua...	[(sexual, 334), (violence, 323), (woman, 168),...	[introduction, report, period, january, decemb...	[(violence, 322), (woman, 168), (force, 99), (...	[cover, submit, request, report, recommend, es...	[(include, 157), (continue, 51), (arm, 44), (a...	[present, pursuant, strategic, unconstitutiona...	[(sexual, 318), (conflictrelated, 111), (natio...

To carry out the analysis, we followed a structured plan of action for each conflict:

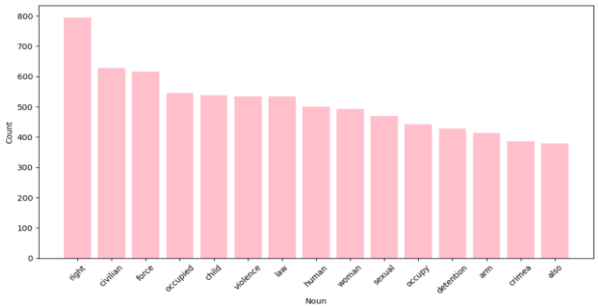
1. For each war, we planned the following:
   → listing of documents with title, date, dominant terms, and sentiment
   → merging all documents and applying TF-IDF for each document, followed by topic modelling and clustering
2. We then combined all documents from both conflicts, removed words that explicitly identified which war the document referred to, and performed topic modelling and clustering to examine whether the UN’s reporting showed a clear divide between the two conflicts or if some clusters/topics contained both. This approach allows us to investigate potential biases in how the UN documents each war.

Analysis and results

1. Ukraine vs Russia

1.1. Word frequency

First, we will look at which words are the most common within all the documents. Looking at the produced bar chart, we can see that the documents discuss the lives of the people and the violence either sexual or physical they are experiencing.



1.2. TF-IDF score

Then to get a better understanding of what each document is about we did TF-IDF and found the top 15 most important words per each document. This allowed us to identify specific themes in each document. For example, the third document seems to put emphasis on the sexual violence women are experiencing during the war. The seventh could be referring to specific attacks that have happened between December and February and how many casualties and injured civilians there had been. Also, the twelfth document looks to be discussing the impact of armed conflict on families, children and their education.

	Top words tf-idf
0	[crimea, right, crimean, court, human, law, ta...
1	[crimea, right, human, ge, assembly, detention...
2	[sexual, violence, woman, conflictrelated, for...
3	[crimea, right, human, province, detention, tr...
4	[pow, civilian, right, oblast, men, august, gr...
5	[force, occupied, occupation, arm, occupy, res...
6	[pow, civilian, attack, right, december, febru...
7	[civilian, conflict, sudan, harm, protection, ...
8	[occupy, temporarily, crimea, control, right, ...
9	[detention, civilian, detainee, liberty, tortu...
10	[pow, torture, internment, civilian, illtreatm...
11	[child, occupied, education, right, school, ca...
12	[temporarily, occupy, occupied, right, law, ge...
13	[pow, right, civilian, occupied, attack, perlo...
14	[temporarily, occupied, right, law, occupy, cr...

1.3. Sentiment analysis

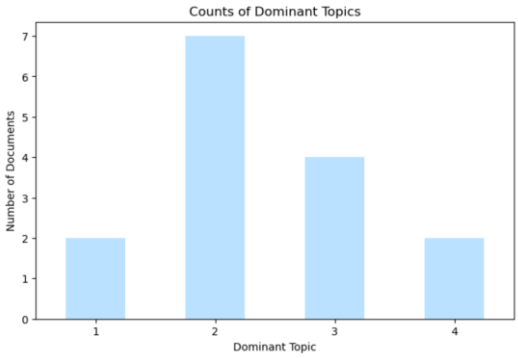
After this, we focused on sentiment analysis, and we wanted to see how unbiased and neutral the language of the reports is. We did polarity and subjectivity analysis on all of the reports. The values for polarity ranged around 0 with minimum polarity of 0.01 and maximum polarity of 0.14. This indicated that all of the documents seem to be written in neutral language, which is what should be expected from documents by the UN. As for subjectivity, the range was from 0.27 to 0.456. We decided to check which document had the highest subjectivity and what sentence had the highest score. The sentence was the following: 'While women and girls continues to constitute the vast majority of victims, men, boys and gender non-conforming persons are also affected,' and it had a score of 1.0. We as humans can differentiate that the sentence is actually objective, but TextBlob interprets it as subjective as it decides that 'vast majority' is an opinionated statement. Based on that, it is safe to assume that all reports are actually quite objective and just TextBlob is not trained enough to score them properly.

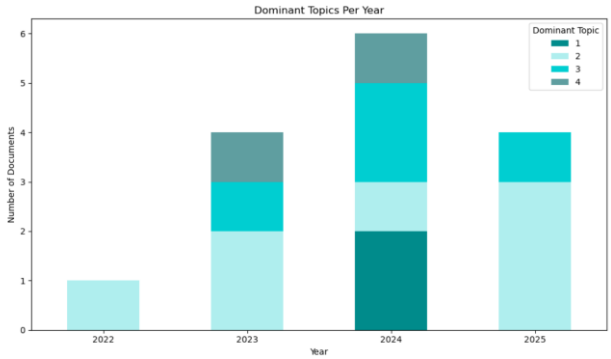
	Title	polarity	subjectivity	sentence with highest subjectivity
0	A/77/220 - 25 July 2022	0.028565	0.285854	(The restrictions risk limiting access in Crim...
1	A/HRC/53/64 - 26 May 2023	0.037560	0.288870	(Five victims whose whereabouts eventually bec...
2	S/2023/413 - 22 June 2023	0.143570	0.456266	(While women and girls continueS to constitute...
3	A/78/340 - 1 September 2023	0.030728	0.281136	(Although the court examined some of these iss...
4	REPORT ON THE HUMAN RIGHTS SITUATION IN UKRAIN...	0.043998	0.298961	(Ukrainian children continued to face disrupte...
5	HUMAN RIGHTS SITUATION DURING THE RUSSIAN OCCU...	0.023607	0.283987	(OHCHR abided strictly by the obligations to '...
6	REPORT ON THE HUMAN RIGHTS SITUATION IN UKRAIN...	0.020296	0.299876	(The war continued to cause devastating civili...
7	S/2024/385 - 14 May 2024	0.067668	0.350394	(The state of the protection of civilians in w...
8	A/79/258 - 30 July 2024	0.044235	0.275549	(The occupying authorities only acknowledged t...
9	TREATMENT OF CIVILIANS DEPRIVED OF THEIR LIBER...	0.031643	0.327505	(States are obliged to take all necessary meas...
10	TREATMENT OF PRISONERS OF WAR AND UPDATE ON TH...	0.011075	0.304085	(Involvement of superiors and coordination bet...
11	THE IMPACT OF THE ARMED CONFLICT AND OCCUPATIO...	0.052448	0.304977	(Contact with interlocutors was established on...
12	A/HRC/59/67 - 28 May 2025	0.040274	0.251200	(respecting, unless absolutely prevented, the ...
13	REPORT ON THE HUMAN RIGHTS SITUATION IN UKRAIN...	0.040393	0.291488	(Based on a site visit, interviews with witnes...
14	A/80/315 - 6 August 2025	0.038795	0.277691	(However, in one case documented by OHCHR duri...

1.4. Topic Modelling

Doing LDA, we decided to try with 4 numbers of topics. The top 20 words per topic were:

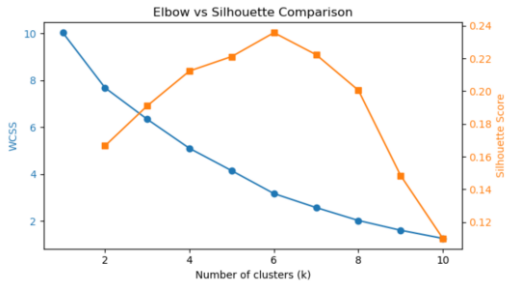
- **Topic 1**: *detainee, kherson, ihl, kharkiv, liberty, collaboration, search, tell, zaporizhzhia, deprive, staff, context, home, ihrl, cultural, passport, beat, conflictrelated, checkpoint, soldier* - Based on this list of words, we can conclude that the documents in this topic are related to detention of people in the conflict zones of Khreson, Kharkiv, and Zaporizhzhia in the year 2024 based on the graphs below. Also, as IHL and IHRL are mentioned, this could mean a focus on international law and breaches in human rights. These reports potentially cover the treatment of detainees and their rights.
- **Topic 2**: *crimea, child, temporarily, education, school, reporting, crimean, property, language, kherson, tatar, expression, citizenship, citizen, medium, detainee, class, zaporizhzhia, arrest, federal* - These documents focus on children and their education probably in the areas of Crimea and Kherson. The reports could cover the impact of occupation on learning establishments and reporting on the communities which were affected. Also, they could focus on detentions and citizenship rights and as the words ‘medium’ and ‘reporting’ appear that could mean that the documents contain media reports and documentation of the issues. The documents from this theme appear each year with the most being written in 2025.
- **Topic 3**: *pow, reporting, child, kill, casualty, august, injure, ihl, girl, internment, interview, damage, frontline, donetsk, strike, hostility, weapon, kherson, city, execution* - These reports could be discussing the front lines of the active conflict zones and the attacks and destruction caused on cities like Donetsk and Kherson. Also, they could be reporting the casualties and injured people, which could include children. POW and internment refer to the treatment of prisoners of war and potential violations of IHL (International Humanitarian Law).
- **Topic 4:** *conflictrelated, girl, protection, rape, survivor, child, sudan, harm, crime, actor, incident, special, displacement, peace, million, congo, commit, accountability, democratic, kill* - This last topic discusses sexual violence on females during wartime, the protection of survivors, displacement of people as well as accountability for crimes committed. Could include references to other conflicts such as the crises in Sudan and Congo. These documents were written in 2023 and 2024.



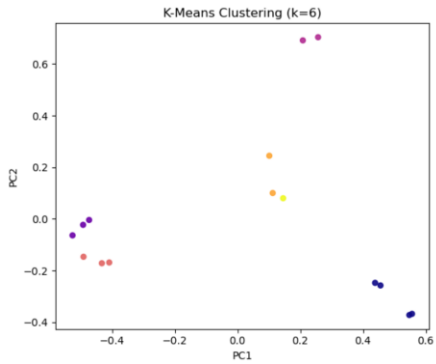


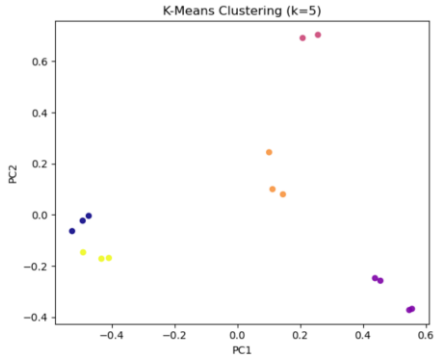
1.5. Clustering

Moving on to the clustering, we get the following graphs for the silhouette scores and WCSS, which tells us that the best number of clusters is 6. We also tried with 5 clusters, as we have only 15 documents, so we wanted to avoid clusters with only one document.



This lead to this graph:





Based on the two clustering graphs, we decided that the second graph(k=5) is better as every cluster contained at least two documents. Now looking into the top 50 words, we have the following five clusters:

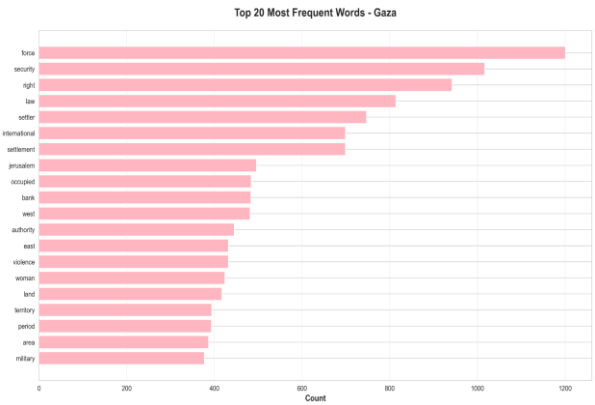
- **Cluster 1 – Human rights violations, detention, and repression in Crimea:** These documents focus on the region of Crimea and the human right violations. Discussing arrests, detentions, trials, and restrictions on expression and language. Emphasis on legal repression.
- **Cluster 2 – Armed conflict and casualties:** Documents focusing on the armed conflict and hostilities at the frontlines along with the amount of casualties and the treatment of POWs in areas like Donetsk, Kherson, and Kharkiv. Details probably include types of injuries, weapons used, and damage on different infrastructures.

- **Cluster 2 - Sexual violence and protection:** This cluster focuses on sexual violence, victims and children protection, displacement of civilians, and accountability. Referencing other countries facing similar issues.
- **Cluster 4 – Children, Education, and Culture:** Reports on children and their right to education as well as discussions on cultural identity and its preservation.
- **Cluster 5 - Occupied territories:** Focus on temporarily occupied territories in Crimea, Zaporizhzhia, and Luhansk and the issues of property and citizenship rights. Also, includes reports on children and their right to education.

2. Palestine vs Israel

2.1. Word frequency

The most frequent words are **force** (1201), **security** (1017), **right** (942), and **law** (814). High-frequency terms such as **settler** (747), **settlement** (699), **Jerusalem** (496), **occupied** (484), **bank** (483) and **west** (481) suggest a central focus on territorial issues and settlement activities. Additionally, recurring terms like **violence** (432), **woman** (424), **land** (417) and **territory** (394) indicate discussions related to the human and geographical impact of the conflict.



2.2. TF-IDF

The highest TF-IDF scores belong to **force** (5.8430), **security** (4.6654), **settler** (4.4512), right (4.1481), and law (3.6726). The analysis of keywords per document reveals specific themes:

- Documents focused on **Settlements and Territory** (e.g., Docs 2, 4, 5, 13, 14, 21, 24) prominently feature words like settler, settlement, land, Jerusalem, outpost, and demolition.
- Documents focused on **Legal and Humanitarian Issues** (e.g., Docs 0, 8, 12, 23) highlight terms such as international, law, humanitarian, violation, accountability, and military.
- Documents focused on **Detention and Violence** (e.g., Docs 1, 6, 9, 17) emphasize terms like detention, torture, killed, woman, arrested, and security.
- A unique focus on **Business and Economic Activity** in relation to settlements is seen in Documents 7 and 20, using keywords like business, company, enterprise, and database.

2.3. Sentiment analysis

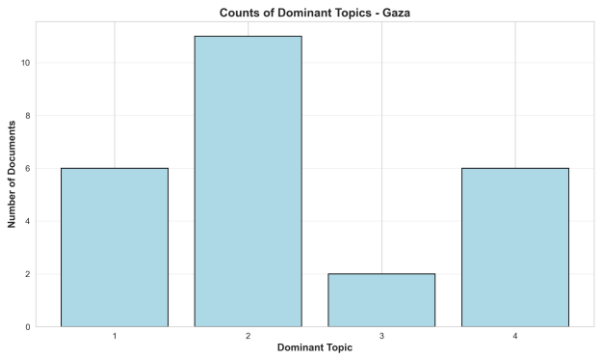
The overall **polarity** is 0.0349, while the document mean is 0.0384. Since this value is very close to zero, it suggests that the documents are written in generally **neutral language**, which is consistent with what is expected from UN reports. The polarity values range from a minimum of -0.0031 to a maximum of 0.1218. Regarding **subjectivity**, the overall score is 0.3654, with individual documents ranging from 0.3310 to 0.4088. The document with the **highest subjectivity** score is indexed as number 16, with a score of 0.4088.

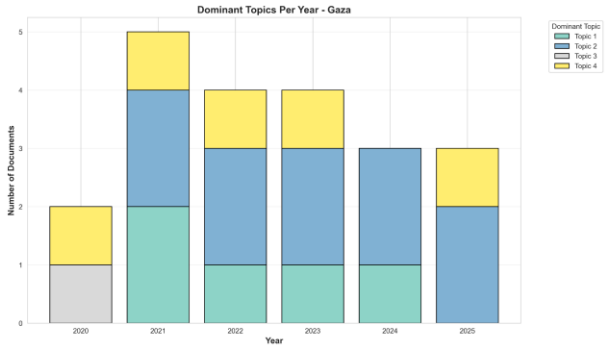
Sentiment Analysis per Document - Gaza

#	Title	Polarity	Subjectivity
0	A/HRC/58/28	0.015073	0.346965
1	A/HRC/52/75	-0.003097	0.343633
2	A/72/564	0.029466	0.348586
3	A/72/565	0.001976	0.352735
4	A/HRC/49/85	0.020097	0.378848
5	A/HRC/52/76	0.023860	0.378503
6	A/78/502	0.015564	0.330992
7	A/HRC/22/63	0.119808	0.383590
8	A/HRC/43/21	0.033303	0.365529
9	A/HRC/49/83	0.044471	0.357428
10	A/76/336	0.030911	0.373878
11	A/HRC/46/63	0.053167	0.347047
12	A/HRC/49/25	0.014868	0.370595

2.4. Topic modelling

- **Topic 1:** Focuses on Security, Rights, and Detention, appears in 6 documents. (*Top words: security, right, woman, force, detention, law, killed, violence, civilian, case, child, arrested*).
- **Topic 2:** Focuses on Settlements and Land, the dominant topic, appearing in 11 documents (*Top words: settler, settlement, land, security, jerusalem, area, force, east, violence, occupied, west, bank, demolition, community, territory*).
- **Topic 3:** Focuses on Business Activity and Occupation, the least frequent, with 2 documents (*Top words: business, activity, enterprise, settlement, right, company, territory, occupied, international*).
- **Topic 4:** Focuses on International Law, Accountability, and Investigations, appears in 6 documents (*Top words: force, international, law, security, right, investigation, humanitarian, violation, military, use, accountability*).

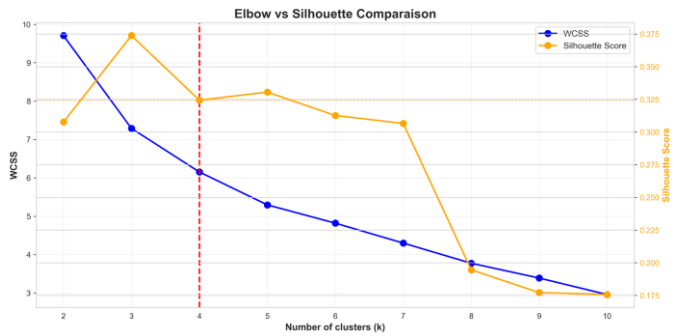


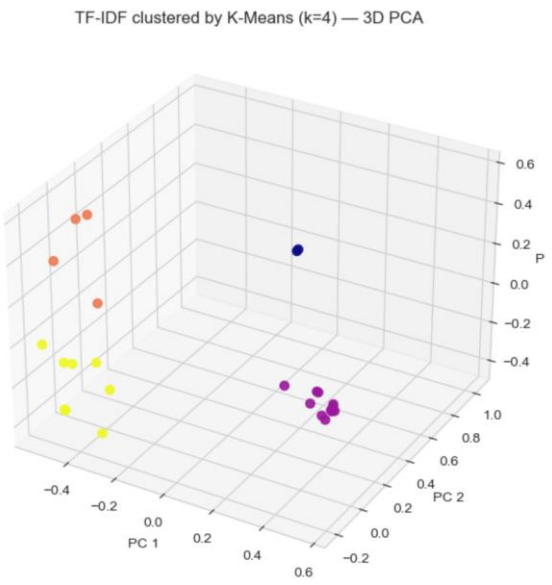


2.5. Clustering

The clustering analysis suggested an optimal number of 4 clusters, with a silhouette score of 0.3011.

- **Cluster 0 - Individual Detention and Violence Against Civilians (4 documents):** Top words include woman, detention, killed, arrested, violence, arbitrary, torture, detained, defender, boy, civilian, illtreatment, journalist, yearold, arrest. This cluster focuses on cases of individual arrests, detention conditions, and violence against specific civilians including women, children, journalists, and human rights defenders.
- **Cluster 1 - Settlement Expansion and Forced Displacement (11 documents):** Top words include settler, land, violence, outpost, demolition, eviction, transfer, structure, property, administration, forced, forcible, syrian, home, construction. This cluster centers on territorial changes, settlement activities, demolitions, and the forced displacement of populations through evictions and property seizures.
- **Cluster 2 - Lethal Force and Accountability for Killings (8 documents):** Top words include investigation, killed, detention, civilian, hostility, killing, accountability, torture, incident, defense, woman, strike, shot, death, illtreatment. This cluster addresses deadly incidents involving civilians, the use of lethal force, military strikes, and the accountability mechanisms (or lack thereof) for investigating these deaths.
- **Cluster 3 - Corporate Activity and Business Accountability (2 documents):** Top words include business, enterprise, company, listed, database, involved, para, response, principle, set, relevant, provide, purpose, included, received. This cluster focuses on corporate entities, business activities in the region, database listings of companies, and their responses to human rights principles and accountability frameworks.





3. Combined

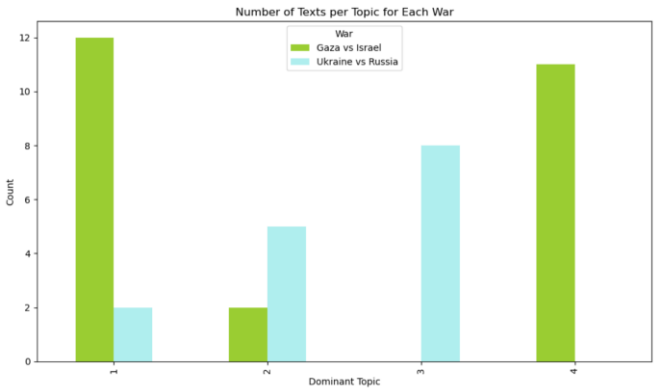
3.1. Data Processing

First, we needed to remove all the words that could identify which document is for which war. We wanted to see what the documents discuss and if they discuss similar issues, so removing any identifying terms would allow us to see that.

3.2. Topic Modelling

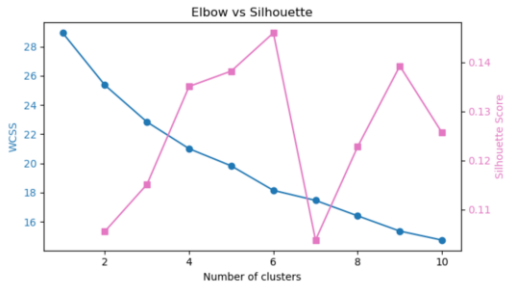
We decided on doing four topics using LDA, and these were the results:

- **Topic 1**: The documents in this topic likely discuss sexual violence, death of civilians, arrests and detention, abuse and the reports/investigations of these crimes. Based on the graph, we can see that this topic contains documents from both wars: 12 from Palestine vs Israel and 2 from Ukraine vs Russia. (Top words: violence, sexual, kill, detention, child, ohchr, investigation, arrest, girl, conflict, reporting, incident, crime, torture, boy)
- **Topic 2:** These documents are probably related to the treatment of detainees, the conditions of the detention facilities, access to health treatment, and reports/documentation on them. This topic again contains both wars with 2 reports on Palestine vs Israel and 5 on Ukraine vs Russia. (Top words: torture, detention, facility, illtreatment, august, enterprise, treatment, detainee, company, reporting, medical, kill, violence, internment, condition)
- **Topic 3:** These documents discuss the effects of occupation on civilians such as detention, restriction on freedom, property rights, lack of access to education and schools. This topic only contains documents from the Ukraine vs Russia war. (Top words: child, detention, occupation, resident, individual, control, reporting, detain, education, school, freedom, social, assembly, december, property)
- **Topic 4:** These documents discuss land issues, construction and expansion, demolition and planning. Based on the graph, we can see that this is a uniquely Palestine vs Israel topic. (Top words: land, violence, property, reporting, child, plan, new, syrian, ohchr, construction, cent, incident, increase, zone, expansion)

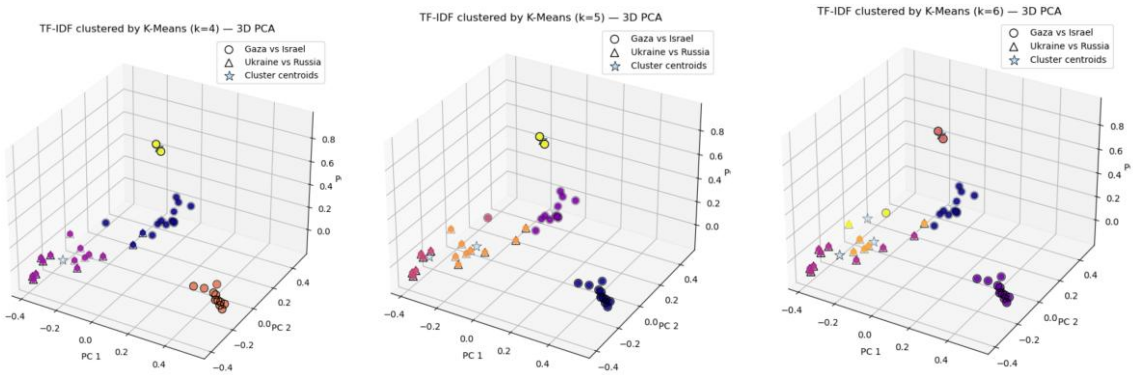


3.3. Clustering

Moving on to the clustering, we get the following graphs for the silhouette scores and WCSS, which tells us that the best number of clusters is 6.

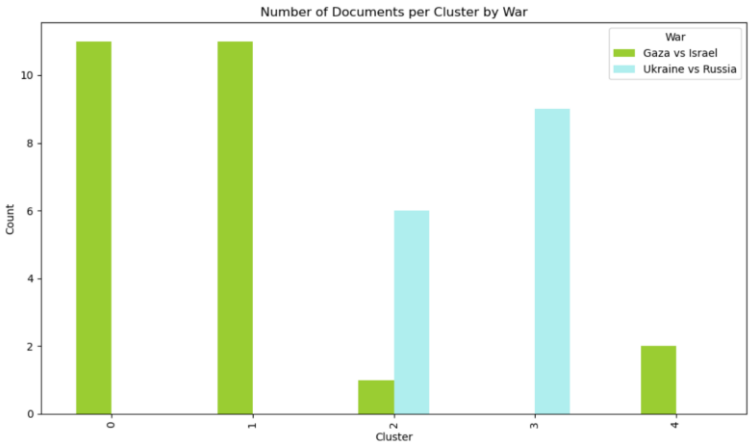


However, looking at the resulting clustering graph, we decided to try with 5 and 4 clusters as well. Ultimately, we decided to stick with 5 clusters, as the cluster separation was good while still not merging themes that are not necessarily related:



Based on the top 50 words, we have the following six clusters:

- **Cluster 0 –** Settlement expansion, land confiscation, demolition, and displacement
- **Cluster 1 –** Lethal force, arrests, detention, and associated violence
- **Cluster 2 -** Detention, Restrictions under occupation, and cultural/educational rights
- **Cluster 3 –** Casualties**,** Conflict-related detention, torture, and sexual violence
- **Cluster 4 -** Involvement in Conflict of companies and corporate entities


Number of Documents per Cluster by War
War
Gaza vs Israel
Ukraine vs Russia
Count
0
2
4
6
8
10
0
1
2
3
4
Cluster

Insights & Implications

1. **What topics does the UN focus on while discussing the civilian protection for both wars?**
   Our results demonstrate that the UN reports prioritize different themes depending on which conflict they are addressing, reflecting the way the UN interprets the main sources of civilian harm in each context.

a. Ukraine vs Russia - looking at the topic modelling that we did on all of our documents regarding this war, we can see four separate topics. These topics put emphasis mostly on the conditions in the detention facilities, treatment of the prisoners of war(POW), children's rights and how their education has been affected, sexual violence that women mostly have experienced, and any occupation-related restrictions.

b. Palestine vs Israel - When doing topic modelling for these documents, we requested four topics. The first topic was focused on security, rights and detention, but it only appeared prominently in six documents. The second topic dealt with settlements, land related issues, and territorial control, and 11 documents were focused on it. The third topic, which was least frequent, was about business activity, but also touched on settlements and territorial control. Lastly, the final topic, containing 6 documents, emphasised on international law, investigations on violations, accountability for wrongdoings. This shows that the focus of these documents predominantly centers on land, settlements, territorial control, and the use of force. Security and detention issues also emerge every so often.

These differences suggest that the UN's policy discourse is shaped more by the specific political/territorial issues associated with each conflict rather than in a universal framework. For Ukraine, the UN discusses occupation-related rights, treatment of detainees, and legal protections. While for Gaza, the documents are heavily focused on land rights, destruction of property, and settler violence. The UN describes the specific type of torment and human rights violations people are experiencing inherent to each context. This, however, can be interpreted as political bias even if it is based on the reality of the situation.

Why does the UN do that? As the UN is a highly political institution, they need to carefully decide what and how to phrase issues without escalating diplomatic conflict. The member states generally have strong and conflicting interests when it comes to these types of conflicts(wars). Because of this, some violations are described using carefully selected legal terminology and certain issues cannot always be emphasised as to not provoke political pushback. Hence, even if issues share common themes, the way to discuss them in a safe political and diplomatic way differs based on the context.

2. **Why did our clustering goal fail even though we removed many identifying terms?**

Following the previous insight, we can understand why it is almost impossible to have clusters containing documents about both wars. The clustering still separates the documents by conflict not because of a technical issue, but rather because of the deep structural differences in how the institution reports on each war. The UN aligns its narrative to the international legal frameworks, which are most relevant to each conflict. Ukraine discussions are about IHL, protection of POWs, laws on occupation and the Geneva Conventions. Palestine touches on

IHRL, resolutions on settlements, and legal frameworks regarding land rights, demolitions and protection of civilians under occupation. Because of this, there is a difference in terminology and metrics used and which types of violations are monitored. Hence, the UN's discourse is structurally shaped by the legal and political context of each conflict, which makes clustering between different wars very difficult.

3. Is there a bias that can be discovered through sentiment analysis?

Looking at our findings, the language is very neutral and factual, which confirms that the UN maintains a strictly neutral tone when discussing both conflicts. This, however, doesn't exactly imply that their prioritization is neutral. What they choose to put emphasis on shows which issues they consider as most urgent/important. The UN has a lot of power when it comes to where the political pressure, humanitarian resources, and media attention is focused. Hence, even if our sentiment analysis tells us that the language is neutral, the repetitions of certain themes/topics as opposed to others frames the nature of each conflict and which violations have been decided to be the most significant.

4. How does the UN shift its priorities over time in conflict-specific ways?

Since there is little overlap in the topic modelling on all the documents combined, and we already shown that it is almost impossible to group reports from different conflicts, we can instead examine how the UN's priorities shift within each conflict over time. The temporal patterns in our topic distributions reveal that the UN's reporting priorities evolve differently across conflicts. In Ukraine, topics emerge and disappear from year to year. For example, the rise of documents discussing detention conditions in 2024. This reflects that their reporting approach is reactive and event-driven, meaning as the intensity or nature of violations change, the UN shifts which areas/themes receive more attention. As for the Gaza vs Israel conflict, the reports display a more stable topic distribution over the years. The consistency suggests a focus on long-standing structural issues as opposed to shifting wartime developments. This shows that for each conflict the reporting pattern is different. This strengthens the implication that the UN discourse is not only shaped by the legal and political context, but also by the different ways its attention evolves over time in response to/despite current events.

These findings address all three goals of our analysis. First, the UN's dominant themes differ across the two conflicts, reflecting the distinct legal frameworks and context-specific forms of civilian harm and human rights violations. Secondly, although the tone of the UN reporting remains consistently neutral, the choice of which issues to prioritise introduces meaningful differences in framing. Lastly, the temporal evolution of topics demonstrates that Ukraine reporting responds to shifting wartime developments, while for Palestine reporting remains anchored in long-standing structural issues. Overall, this suggests that the UN's discourse is shaped by a combination of legal constraints, political sensitivity, and conflict-specific temporal dynamics. Together these influence how civilian protection is framed across different wars.

Recommendations

1. Increase the transparency in how priorities are set for each conflict when reporting.

Our findings show that the UN focuses on different issues in Ukraine like detention conditions, treatment of prisoners of war, and occupation law while in Gaza they emphasise on land, settlement, and territorial control. These differences shape the discourse. The main goal should be to avoid perceptions of political bias and to do that the UN should explicitly communicate why they prioritize certain issues in specific conflicts. For example, a methodology explaining the following points could be included in their reports to make them more transparent:

- The legal framework that led the reporting
- Why and how each topic was selected
- Why and which types of violations are systematically monitored while others are documented only when verified evidence is obtained

This transparency could be very helpful in clarifying that the issue selection is driven by mandate and context and not political favouritism.

2. Expand monitoring practices to report emerging issues in long-term conflicts.

The temporal analysis that we did showcase that the UN's reports on Ukraine were reactive and event-driven, while for Palestine their reports remained stable and centred on structural issues. Because of this, newly emerging harms in Gaza are at risk of being underrepresented. The UN could benefit from having a wider monitoring strategy for long-term conflicts where they:

- Continue to document long-standing structural issues.
- Integrate event-responsive procedures that document arising violations.

This way they can ensure that their reports reflect both long-term patterns and new escalations. This would improve the UN's ability to provide assessments that are both comprehensive and timely reported.

3. Create a cross-conflict vocabulary/indicators for civilian-protection discussions

The core civilian-protection principles such as treatment of detainees, attacks on civilians and access to assistance are universal for every conflict. Our clustering results show that the documents remain almost entirely separated by conflict, which is mostly due to the conflict-specific terminology and different emphasis. To address this, the UN could implement a shared vocabulary or some standardized indicators for civilian protection that are universal across conflicts. This would not mean removing the context but rather making sure that similar violations are described using comparable terminology, metrics are reported consistently, and important protection themes appear in all contexts/conflicts where they are relevant. This could help to steer clear of the perception that similar violations are treated unequally depending on which actors are involved.

Limitations & Next Steps

An important limitation of our analysis stems from the type of documents we initially selected. We chose to include documents that follow the same structure and are reliable. Hence, we decided on reports written by the General Assembly and the Human Rights Council. While this ensured consistency, that also meant that the documents contained pretty much the same information with little deviation between documents, which made it difficult to detect meaningful differences and create distinct topics/clusters. To address this, we broadened the dataset to include different types of documents for the Ukraine vs Russia war so that we could achieve a better division of documents and see a wider range of issues. Between the two analyses on the two wars, I think the fact that there was a wider range of different types of documents for Ukraine and Russia, allowed us to have more defined and easier to separate clusters/topics. As for Gaza and Israel, we went with only documents by the General Assembly and the Human Rights Council. Their structural similarity and focus on recurring long-term issues is likely the reason the silhouette score defined three clusters as the best choice. This also helps explain the stability of the temporal topic distribution that was observed compared to the one for Ukraine. For a more comprehensive and structurally comparable analysis across different conflicts, future work should include a wider range of document types for Gaza-Israel as well.

There are different ways this project could be extended. One way is to expand the analysis on additional conflicts and see what the UN discusses about each war and what are their priorities. Currently, there are many ongoing issues around the world so finding more documents and also comparing the amount of documents that can be found about each conflict would be a good extension of this project. Another important next step could be examining how the priorities of the UN evolve in relation to major conflicts like escalations, ceasefires, resolutions. This was part of our initial plan, however, the documents we selected were largely focused on describing the conditions rather than accounts of decision-making processes. This made it difficult to extract such information through text analysis. To make progress in this area, we would need more focused documents and applying more advanced NLP methods. Overall, refining the document selection strategy and broadening the range of data sources could significantly strengthen the analysis.

Conclusion

Our analysis showcases that the UN's discourse on civilian protection is shaped by the political and legal context of each conflict rather than by any uniform reporting framework. The topic modelling reveals a clear thematic divergence between the two conflicts we are analysing. Ukraine's reports are centred on detention conditions, treatment of prisoners of war, and the violations governed by IHL. On the other hand, Palestine documents prioritize land issues, settlements, territorial control, and use of force. Hence, even after we tried to remove identifying terms, the clustering remained conflict-specific, which indicates that the differences are embedded in the reporting structure of the UN.

Our sentiment analysis confirmed that the UN's language was consistently neutral across conflicts, but that neutrality doesn't translate to neutrality in prioritization. The UN's emphasis on certain themes shapes which issues will gain political visibility and attention internationally. The temporal analysis also strengthens the fact that the institution has different reporting priorities when discussing different conflicts. Ukraine's coverage shifts in response to new developments, while Gaza's reporting is more stable long-term.

Together these findings demonstrate that the UN communications are context-depending and strategically structured to navigate geopolitical constraints. The key takeaway is that the UN's reporting is not just a record of the violations, but rather a negotiated report that showcases legal mandates, diplomatic sensitivity, and conflict-specific pressures.